A Tiny Adventure Time Episode That Turned Out to Be Huge

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Some cartoon villains are just silly. The Ice King is different: funny, sad, and a little scary all at once.

A new look back at Adventure Time calls one short episode from 13 years ago a **masterpiece**. The episode is "Simon & Marcy," season 5, episode 14. It runs about ten minutes, and streams now on Hulu, Disney Plus, and HBO Max.

At first, the Ice King seemed simple. He lived in a mountain home with his penguins, used icy powers, and tried to capture princesses. Heroes Finn and Jake usually stopped him.

Then the story changed. In season 4, episode 25, called "Remember Me," Marceline, the **vampire** queen, calls him by a real name for the first time: Simon. That one word hints at a past the audience had not seen.

"Simon & Marcy" fills in part of that past. Apart from a short opening basketball game, it is a **flashback** set almost 1,000 years before the main story. After the Mushroom War, which changed Earth into the fantasy land of Ooo, Simon travels through a **ruined** city with a young girl named Marcy. They look out for each other in an empty, changed world.

Simon carries a magic crown on his belt. When he wears it, he can control ice and snow, but it also makes it harder for him to think clearly. Singing the theme from Cheers seems to help him stay steady, at least a little.

What makes it special is not only its spooky mood. It helps explain Simon and Marceline, and it opened the way for more stories about them across nearly 300 episodes and a later **spinoff**. A tiny episode, in other words, turned out to be a very big one.

Word Treasure

masterpiece -- A work that is considered one of the very best of its kind.

flashback -- A scene that shows something that happened earlier in the story.

vampire -- A creature in stories that lives a very long time and is often said to drink blood.

spinoff -- A new show or story that grows out of an earlier show and follows some of its characters.

ruined -- Badly damaged or broken down, so it is no longer in good shape.

Background you need

Adventure Time is a cartoon about heroes Finn and Jake in a fantasy world.

The Ice King begins as a funny villain who uses ice powers and tries to capture princesses.

A flashback is a part of a story that goes back to an earlier time to show how things came to be.

In this episode, the flashback shows Simon and young Marcy looking after each other in a changed world after a war, which helps explain who the Ice King once was.

Break it down

LEAD: A look back calls the short Adventure Time episode 'Simon & Marcy' a masterpiece.
KEY EVENT: The episode fills in part of the Ice King's past.
+- WHO: Simon, young Marcy, Marceline, Finn and Jake
+- WHEN: A flashback set almost 1,000 years before the main story
+- WHAT: Simon and Marcy travel through a ruined city and look out for each other
EVIDENCE: In 'Remember Me,' Marceline calls the Ice King by his real name, Simon, for the first time.
EFFECT: The episode helps explain Simon and Marceline and opened the way for more stories across nearly 300 episodes and a later spinoff.

Why it matters

A short story can change how we see a character, showing that understanding someone's past can make a familiar story feel richer and more surprising.

Test what you remember

1. In 'Remember Me,' what does Marceline do for the first time?

- (A) She captures a princess
- (B) She wins a basketball game
- (C) She calls the Ice King by his real name, Simon
- (D) She takes the magic crown

2. How far before the main story is the flashback in 'Simon & Marcy' set?

- (A) Ten minutes before
- (B) Almost 1,000 years before
- (C) Thirteen years before
- (D) Nearly 300 episodes before

3. What does Simon carry on his belt?

- (A) A penguin
- (B) A basketball
- (C) A magic crown
- (D) A mountain home

4. What seems to help Simon stay steady, at least a little?

- (A) Singing the theme from Cheers
- (B) Playing basketball with Finn and Jake
- (C) Living in a mountain home
- (D) Capturing princesses

5. Where does 'Simon & Marcy' stream now?

- (A) Only on Hulu
- (B) On Hulu, Disney Plus, and HBO Max
- (C) Only on HBO Max
- (D) Only on Disney Plus

6. Why is the tiny episode described as very big?

- (A) It is the first episode ever made
- (B) It is the longest episode of the series
- (C) It ends the whole series
- (D) It helps explain Simon and Marceline and opened the way for more stories about them

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. The new look back: Calls 'Simon & Marcy' a masterpiece.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):